

SU(N) Yang-Mills Theory and Scalar Fields

Source: Perimeter Scholars International, *Quantum Field Theory II*, Tutorial 8; 11 worked parts.

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Question prompts paraphrased from the official Perimeter PSI Online sheet; the equations and notation follow the source.

1 Coupling to Scalar Fields

Let $\phi_i(x)$ be a scalar field in a representation r of $SU(N)$, with $i = 1, \dots, \dim r$.

1. Determine the dimension of the group $SU(N)$.

Solution. An $N \times N$ complex matrix has $2N^2$ real dimensions. The hermitian condition, $U_{ik}^* U_{jk} = \delta_{ij}$, is N^2 constraints. In addition, $\det U = 1$ gives an extra constraint. Therefore, $\dim SU(N) = N^2 - 1$.

2. Determine the dimension of the fundamental representation of $SU(N)$.

Solution. The fundamental representation of $SU(N)$ is $N \times N$ complex matrices, which has dimension N .

3. The adjoint action is defined by

$$\text{Ad}_g(T^a) \equiv g T^a g^{-1}. \quad (1.1)$$

Thus there is a $\dim G \times \dim G$ matrix $C(g)$ such that

$$g T^a g^{-1} = C^{ab}(g) T^b. \quad (1.2)$$

Expand g and $C(g)$ infinitesimally and use

$$[T_i, T_j] = i f_{ijk} T_k \quad (1.3)$$

to derive the adjoint generators

$$(T_i)_{jk} = if_{ijk}. \quad (1.4)$$

Solution.

$$\text{Ad}(g)Y = (I + \epsilon X)Y(I - \epsilon X) = I + \epsilon[X, Y] = (I + \epsilon \text{ad}(X))Y \implies \text{ad}(X)Y = [X, Y]. \quad (1.5)$$

Taking $X = T^a, Y = T^b$, we have

$$\text{ad}(T^a)^{bc}T^c = if^{abc}T^c \implies \text{ad}(T^a)^{bc} = if^{abc}. \quad (1.6)$$

4. Determine the dimension of the adjoint representation of $SU(N)$.

Solution. As we have seen above, the adjoint representation of the Lie algebra is a $\dim G \times \dim G$ matrix. Therefore,

$$\dim \text{adj}(su(N)) = \dim SU(N). \quad (1.7)$$

Now consider the local transformation

$$\phi_i(x) \mapsto g_{ij}(x)\phi_j(x), \quad g(x) = \exp[i\alpha_m(x)T_r^m], \quad (1.8)$$

where T_r^m are the $su(N)$ generators in the representation r and the $\alpha_m(x)$ are spacetime-dependent group parameters. Require the covariant derivative to transform as

$$D_\mu \phi_i(x) \mapsto g_{ij}(x)D_\mu \phi_j(x), \quad (1.9)$$

and define, with matrix indices suppressed,

$$D_\mu \phi = \partial_\mu \phi - ieA_\mu \phi, \quad A_\mu(x) = A_\mu^m(x)T_r^m. \quad (1.10)$$

1. Derive the finite gauge-transformation law of $A_\mu(x)$ required by the covariance of $D_\mu \phi$.

Solution.

$$D_\mu \phi \rightarrow D'_\mu g \phi = (\partial_\mu g)\phi + g\partial_\mu \phi - ieA'_\mu g \phi = g(\partial_\mu \phi - ieA_\mu \phi), \quad (1.11)$$

which implies

$$A'_\mu = gA_\mu g^{-1} - \frac{i}{e}(\partial_\mu g)g^{-1}. \quad (1.12)$$

2. For infinitesimal $\alpha_m(x)$, show that

$$\delta A_\mu^a = \frac{1}{e}D_\mu \alpha_a, \quad D_\mu \alpha = \partial_\mu \alpha + ie[\alpha, A_\mu]. \quad (1.13)$$

Solution.

$$\begin{aligned}
A_\mu^a R(T^a) &\rightarrow (I + i\alpha_b R(T^b)) A_\mu^a R(T^a) (I - i\alpha_b R(T^b)) + \frac{1}{e} (\partial_\mu \alpha_b) R(T^b) (I + i\alpha_a R(T^a)) \\
&= A_\mu^a R(T^a) + i\alpha_b [R(T^b), R(T^a)] A_\mu^a + \frac{1}{e} (\partial_\mu \alpha_b) R(T^b) \\
&= A_\mu^a R(T^a) + \frac{1}{e} D_\mu \alpha,
\end{aligned} \tag{1.14}$$

from which we can recognise α as the adjoint representation of $su(N)$.

3. Prove that the Lagrangian

$$\mathcal{L} = -(D_\mu \phi)^\dagger D^\mu \phi - m^2 \phi^\dagger \phi - \frac{\lambda}{2} (\phi^\dagger \phi)^2 \tag{1.15}$$

is invariant under the local scalar transformation and the gauge-field transformation found above.

Solution. It can be easily seen through the transformation of ϕ and $D_\mu \phi$.

4. Extract every Feynman rule from this Lagrangian that contains at least one scalar line.

Solution. Expanding the covariant derivative, we have

$$|D_\mu \phi|^2 = |\partial_\mu \phi|^2 + ie A_\mu (\phi^\dagger \partial_\mu \phi - \phi \partial_\mu \phi^\dagger) + e^2 A_\mu^2 |\phi|^2, \tag{1.16}$$

and the Feynman rules can be read off.

5. Apply Noether's theorem to obtain the conserved currents.

Solution.

$$j_\mu^a = \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial^\mu \phi)} \delta \phi^a + \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial^\mu \phi^\dagger)} \delta \phi^{\dagger a} = i(D_\mu \phi)^\dagger R(T^a) \phi - i\phi^\dagger R(T^a) (D_\mu \phi). \tag{1.17}$$

2 Zero Modes of the Yang--Mills Lagrangian

Take the unfixed Yang--Mills Lagrangian

$$\mathcal{L} = -\frac{1}{2g^2} \text{Tr}(F^{\mu\nu} F_{\mu\nu}), \tag{2.1}$$

with the trace over adjoint indices and arbitrary N in $SU(N)$.

1. Expand the F^2 term, isolate the quadratic terms containing two derivatives, and write them as

$$\int d^4x A_\mu^a(x) D_x^{\mu\nu} A_\nu^a(x). \tag{2.2}$$

Solution.

$$\begin{aligned} S &= -\frac{1}{4g} \int d^d x F_{\mu\nu}^a F^{a\mu\nu} \\ &= -\frac{1}{2g} \int d^d x A_\nu (-\partial^2 \eta^{\mu\nu} + \partial^\mu \partial^\nu) A_\mu + \dots, \end{aligned} \tag{2.3}$$

where the interacting terms are suppressed.

2. Show that there is a nonzero field B_μ satisfying

$$D_x^{\mu\nu} B_\nu(x) = 0. \tag{2.4}$$

Hint: regard $D^{\mu\nu}$ as an integral kernel and inspect its momentum-space representation. Explain why this zero mode obstructs inversion of the quadratic operator before gauge fixing.

Solution. It is easy to see that any field of the form $\partial_\mu \omega$ is the kernel of the operator $D_a^{\mu\nu}$. Therefore, $D_a^{\mu\nu}$ is clearly not invertible and hence we need the Faddeev-Popov procedure.